



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
COLUMBIA BUSINESS
SCHOOL

FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR COLUMBIA

ABOUT THE SCHOOL

Located in New York City, Columbia Business School (CBS) highlights that it is at the "center of business," helping bright students think like entrepreneurs and helping them develop as leaders.

The symbiotic relationship between CBS and the business world is a major program benefit, and each year many business leaders visit the campus to speak to b-school students and to teach classes. Indeed, CBS notes on its website, "more business leaders visit our campus than any other top business school." Because of its NYC location, the school also attracts more than 100 real-world practitioners as faculty (adjunct) in the business school. While fortifying Columbia's strength in finance, CBS has made experiential learning, entrepreneurial thinking, and global perspectives the cornerstones of the program.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Known for its strengths in a wide variety of areas, including accounting, finance, general management, entrepreneurship, economics, media, marketing, healthcare/pharma, consumer goods and real estate.

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 5,876	MBA Class Size: 754
Admissions Selectivity: 19%	Yield: 68%
Total Tuition: \$154,752	

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Finance 34.3%; Consulting 32.6%; Technology 13.8%; Starting Own Business 5%
Top Recruiters: McKinsey, Bain, Citi, BCG, PwC Strategy&, Deloitte, Goldman Sachs
Avg. Base Salary: \$150,000 Employment in 3 months: 94%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	13	-	5	6	11	-		9
Financial Times	5	5	5	6	6	7	7	6
Forbes	-	7	-	4	-	6	-	7
The Economist	5	7	10	12	11	-		12
US News	8	8	8	8	10	9	9	6

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs	Avg. GMAT: 727	Avg. GPA: 3.6
Int'l Students: 47%	Female Students: 38%	

Deadlines for 2020-2021:

Early decision: Oct 2, 2020

Regular decision, Jan. 2021 start: Oct. 2, 2020

Regular decision, Aug. 2021 start: April 9, 2020

Sources: Columbia, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2020-2021

Essay Analysis: How to Tackle the Columbia Essays

By Karen Hamou

Fortuna Admissions Expert Coach Karen Hamou is a Columbia MBA alum and former Deloitte Consulting recruiting lead.

This year, Columbia Business School introduces a new essay question that goes further than before to push candidates to get personal.

Short Answer Question: What is your immediate post-MBA professional goal? (50 characters)

The Admissions team wants you to be direct, succinct and demonstrate direction (ambition is good but be realistic). This is an opportunity to provide a simple headline that lays the groundwork for subsequent essays on your career goals and reasons for pursuing the Columbia MBA. But note the subtlety that asks what you envision doing, rather than the position you hope to secure in a specific company. Rather than a narrow path such as 'strategy consultant at Bain' or 'senior analyst at Morgan Stanley,' you can open things up by indicating what you hope to achieve in a sector, such as 'consultant focusing on clean technology' or 'structure investment deals in real estate.'

There is no right answer here, but whatever you choose should be coherent and credible based on your past experience combined with the Columbia MBA. Columbia is looking to see that you know what you want to do, have a general understanding of that role, and that you understand the paths that would be available to you coming out of Columbia.

Essay 1: Through your resume and recommendations, we have a clear sense of your professional path to date. What are your career goals over the next 3-5 years and what, in your imagination, would be your long-term dream job? (500 words)

A common mistake here is to focus on where you have been rather than where you are going. Columbia specifically asks what your future career goals are, and so a substantial portion of the word count should specifically address short and long term goals (at least 250 words, if not more). It often helps to start with a brief hook to show what inspires you to take the path that you will then lay out. It can be a brief anecdote, a quote, a reflection on something that happened in your past, etc. Then, offer a (very brief) paragraph explaining what you have done on that career path to date, just to put a bit more context around the goals you will then introduce.

Short-term goals can be more specific than long-term goals. You certainly need to have a general idea of what you would like to do in the long term, but given that it would be quite a few years out, the admissions committee is not expecting the same level of detail there as they are for the immediate post-MBA goals. Again, Columbia is looking to see that you have a clear understanding of where its MBA can take you (and then essay 2 will show how the MBA will help you get there).



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Essay 2: Why do you feel Columbia Business School is a good fit for you? (250 Words)

This feels very similar to previous years' prompt ('why do you want to be at the very center of business?') except the wording is much more straightforward. This essay question prompts you to explain why CBS is uniquely positioned to help you achieve your goals. It is a great opportunity to demonstrate that you have done your homework and are passionate about attending Columbia. You should showcase your deep knowledge of the school and the engagement that you've had with members of the Columbia community. Even though it isn't directly in the essay prompt this year as it was previously, you should still explain not only why Columbia's campus life is right for you, but also why want to pursue the MBA in New York City, as NYC is such an integral part of the Columbia experience.

NEW Essay 3: Tell us about your favorite book, movie or song and why it resonates with you. (250 Words)

This is the kind of question that can put even the most confident wordsmith into a panic in hopes of delivering something memorable, genuine and distinctive. It is similar to last year's "who is a leader you admire, and why," in the sense that Columbia cares less about the book, movie or song you choose, but rather the values, characteristics and insights that your choice conveys about what makes you tick. Just as any work of art – literature, film, music – has the ability to transform or reflect unspoken truths, the Admissions Committee wants to understand what moves you.

This essay is where you can really display who you are under the surface, beyond the ambitious achiever with a sparkling record of successes. While essay 1 shows the professional path you want to take in life, essay 3 can add the additional depth of the type of person, and business leader, you want to be. So whether your artistic choice is an undisputed classic, political satire or a Steampunk thriller, do not get stuck trying to pick the perfect, most impressive one. What is much more important here is WHY you have selected this story, what you learned from it, how it inspires you, and how it may have impacted your professional or personal decisions.

Optional Essay:

Is there any further information that you wish to provide the Admissions Committee? If so, use this space to provide an explanation of any areas of concern in your academic record or your personal history. This does not need to be a formal essay. You may submit bullet points. (Maximum 500 Words)



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Tip #1 - Advantages of applying early

Columbia Business School operates on a rolling admissions process – both for early and regular decisions – and applications are reviewed in the order that they are received. There are clear advantages for applying early to Columbia, as the pool will be smaller and your application will likely gain greater visibility. In fact Columbia offers Early Decision, which commits you to the school if you are admitted, or you forego the \$6,000 tuition down payment you have made. But for a school that feels its New York location and Ivy League pedigree should make it a compelling choice for MBA applicants, they consistently lose people to the likes of HBS and Wharton. So if you want to send a signal of your commitment to CBS, Early Decision is a great way to do so.

For those who have scored on the lower end of the school's GMAT range, you may specifically want to consider Early Decision; Admissions can be more flexible at this initial stage, knowing that they can make up for this shortfall in the regular pool. As one of the leading schools for finance Columbia is typically quant driven, so you still want to demonstrate your comfort with numbers, preferably with the GMAT but otherwise through courses on your undergrad transcript, the CFA or online courses in stats, accounting, or calculus. Bear in mind that while the rest of the top b-schools wait until January to receive the second round of applications, Columbia is reviewing files from early October onwards, so don't wait until the New Year.

Tip #2 - Work experience

On average, Columbia Business School students come into the program with five years professional experience and most have at least three years. If you have less than three years of work, it will be that much harder to get admitted. You will have to demonstrate to Admissions that your professional experience is either unusual or differentiating; or that you have had some significant achievements, despite your shorter professional experience.

Tip #3 - Location, location, location

Particularly given Columbia's new branding campaign ("At the very center of business"), the importance of the business school's location becomes more important to recognize than ever. One of the essay questions specifically asks about how the city will impact your experience. If you aren't currently in NYC, you need to show the Admissions team that you understand what it would be like to live there and how you would take advantage all that's on offer (for instance, speaker series, internships, networking).

And of course New York is more than just Wall Street. From media to advertising, consulting to real estate, the school has faculty expertise and Centers of Excellence that reflect the diversity of the Big Apple. The new Columbia Startup Lab launched in June '14 in NYC's Silicon Alley, helping CBS students and alumni develop their new ideas and pursue their ventures after graduation. The city is fast-paced, cosmopolitan and decisive, so how do you fit into Columbia's New York culture?

Tip #4 - Interviewing

Candidates typically get to choose whom they want to be interviewed by from a list of alumni who are close by. It's advisable to choose someone with similar career interests, if possible. The interviewer will only be able to see your resume so will not have your full application to review. There will be the standard questions related to "why b-school, career goals, team work experience, etc." But you may likely be asked to focus on why you would choose Columbia over other top programs, as Columbia sometimes loses out to these competitors.



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Tip #5 - To the point with your essays

Columbia has a short essay (50 characters) that asks about your immediate post-MBA professional goal. The Admissions team wants you to be direct, succinct and demonstrate direction (ambition is good but be realistic). There is no room for elaborate statements. This is an opportunity to provide a simple headline that lays the groundwork for subsequent essays on your career goals and reasons for pursuing the Columbia MBA. But note the subtle difference between asking about your post-MBA goal, rather than the position you hope to secure in a specific company. Rather than a narrow path such as 'strategy consultant at Bain' or 'senior analyst at Morgan Stanley,' you can open things up by indicating what you hope to achieve in a sector, 'consultant focusing on clean technology' or 'structuring investment deals in real estate.' There is no right answer of course, but whatever you choose should be coherent and credible based on your past experience combined with the Columbia MBA.

Tip #6 - Positioning for the J-Term

Columbia is alone among the top US business schools in offering a January intake. So if you are determined to secure a place without waiting until the following September this could be a great option for you. But there are a couple of aspects of the program for you to be aware of that could influence your admissions success.

First, the 'J-Term' at Columbia replaces the summer internship with a semester of study. You pretty much have the campus to yourselves, before joining up with the Columbia students who are returning to complete their second year. The program is not really intended for career switchers who needed a summer internship to open up new opportunities. The J-Term class tends to be dominated by consultants who will be heading back to McKinsey, Bain or BCG, people from family businesses, and entrepreneurs. So when Columbia asks you why you are pursuing an MBA at this time, you'd better get your career story straight. If it's apparent that you are looking to make a major shift that requires an internship, the admissions office may well feel you are not best suited to this program format.

The J-Term is also very international, with US citizens making up less than half the class. So if you have professional or academic experience outside your home country it will be worth pointing to a global mindset that will ensure you thrive in this particular New York melting pot.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Johnson Cornell, Yale SOM and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at: FortunaAdmissions.com

